GLOSSARY

Glossary

Every musical word in the Handbook, in one line, with the page where it is explained.

a tempo back to the speed before p.78

accelerando (accel.) gradually faster p.78

accent a > over a note: start it more strongly p.75

acciaccatura a tiny note with a slash, crushed in as fast as possible p.84

accidental a sharp, flat or natural written before a note; it lasts until the bar line p.35

Adagio slow, at ease p.78

Alberti bass a broken chord in the left hand: low, high, middle, high (C G E G) p.148

Allegro fast and lively p.78

anacrusis an upbeat: notes before the first full bar p.61

Andante at a walking pace p.78

appoggiatura a tiny note without a slash; it leans, taking half the main note's time p.84

articulation how notes are joined or separated: slurs, staccato, tenuto, accents p.75

augmented triad a triad with 3 + 3 keys between p.109

bar a group of beats between two bar lines p.46

Baroque music of about 1600–1750: Bach, Handel p.155

bass clef the F clef: its two dots hug the line for bass F p.26

beam a thick line joining quavers or semiquavers into a beat p.61

beat the steady pulse you count p.46

binary form two sections, A B p.152

broken chord the notes of a chord played one after another p.138

cadence the last two chords of a phrase: musical punctuation p.135

cantabile in a singing style p.75

chord three or more notes played together p.106

circle of fifths the keys in a circle: go right, one more sharp; go left, one more flat p.101

Classical music of about 1750–1820: Haydn, Mozart p.155

clef the sign at the start of the staff that names one line p.26

coda an ending section; jump to it at "To Coda" p.67

compound time each beat is a dotted note and divides into three (6/8, 9/8, 12/8) p.58

crescendo (cresc.) getting louder, little by little p.72

crotchet a note worth one beat in 4/4 p.49

da capo (D.C.) "from the head": go back to the beginning p.67

dal segno (D.S.) "from the sign": go back to the segno p.67

diminished triad a triad with 2 + 2 keys between p.109

diminuendo (dim.) getting softer, little by little p.72

dolce sweetly p.75

dominant the 5th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (V) p.112

dot adds half the note's value p.52

duplet two notes in the time of three p.61

dynamics the signs for loud and soft: pp p mp mf f ff p.72

enharmonic two names for one key, such as F♯ and G♭ p.35

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

fermata a pause: hold the note longer than written p.78

Fine "the end": after a D.C. or D.S., stop here p.67

five-finger position one finger on each of five keys in a row p.159

flat (♭) the very next key to the left p.35

form the plan of a whole piece, in letters p.152

forte (f) loud p.72

grand staff treble and bass staves joined by a brace p.26

hairpin a crescendo or diminuendo sign that opens or closes p.72

hemiola two bars of three felt as three bars of two p.64

homophonic a tune with chords underneath p.148

imitation another hand or voice copies the idea p.146

interval the distance between two notes p.38

inversion a chord with a note other than the root at the bottom p.115

key the scale a piece is built on, and its home note p.95

key signature the sharps or flats at the start of every line p.95

Largo very slow and broad p.78

leading note the 7th note of the scale, one key below home p.89

ledger line a short line for a note above or below the staff p.29

legato smoothly joined p.75

major scale tone, tone, semitone, tone, tone, tone, semitone p.89

major triad a triad with 3 + 2 keys between p.109

metronome mark ♩ = 76: 76 beats in a minute p.78

mezzo (m) "half": mp half soft, mf half loud p.72

Middle C the C nearest the middle of the keyboard, on a ledger line between the staves p.22

minim a note worth two crotchets p.49

minor scale the major scale on the same note with 3, 6 and 7 one key lower p.92

minor triad a triad with 2 + 3 keys between p.109

Moderato at a moderate speed p.78

modulation changing key during a piece p.150

monophonic one line alone p.148

mordent the note, its neighbour above (or below), the note p.84

motif a short idea of 2 to 6 notes that comes back p.144

natural (♮) cancels a sharp or flat p.35

octave from one note to the next of the same name: 11 keys between p.41

ornament a small sign for a quick group of notes around the main note p.84

pedal (sustain) the right pedal: notes keep ringing until you lift it p.81

perfect cadence V to I: a full stop p.135

phrase a musical sentence, often 4 bars p.144

pianissimo (pp) very soft p.72

piano (p) soft p.72

plagal cadence IV to I: the "Amen" p.135

polyphonic two or more tunes at once p.148

Presto very fast p.78

progression a trip from chord to chord p.140

pulse the steady beat underneath the music p.46

quaver half a crotchet p.49

rallentando (rall.) gradually slower p.78

GLOSSARY · CONTINUED

relative minor the minor key with the same key signature, a minor 3rd below p.92

repeat sign two dots and a double bar: play the bars again p.67

rest a silence of a set length p.49

ritardando (rit.) gradually slower p.78

Romantic music of about 1820–1900: Chopin, Schumann p.155

rondo A B A C A: the first idea keeps coming back p.152

root the note a chord is built on and named after p.106

rubato time stretched and given back, for expression p.64

scale the notes of a key in order, up or down p.89

semibreve a whole note: four crotchets p.49

semiquaver half a quaver p.49

semitone the very next key: no key between p.22

sequence the same shape repeated higher or lower p.146

seventh chord a triad with one more 3rd on top p.118

sforzando (sfz) one note made suddenly strong p.72

sharp (♯) the very next key to the right p.35

sight-reading playing music at first sight p.163

simple time each beat divides into two (2/4, 3/4, 4/4) p.55

slash chord C/E: the chord, then the bass note p.127

slur a curve over different notes: join them p.75

staccato a dot: short, detached p.75

staff the five lines and four spaces music is written on p.26

subdominant the 4th note of the scale, and the chord built on it (IV) p.112

swing pairs of quavers played long–short p.64

syncopation the stress falls off the beat p.64

tempo the speed of the beat p.46

tenuto a line: hold the note its full length p.75

ternary form A B A: out, away and back p.152

texture how many lines sound at once, and how they fit p.148

theme and variations one tune, changed each time it returns p.152

tie a curve joining two notes of the same pitch: one longer sound p.52

time signature top: how many beats; bottom: which note gets one beat p.55

tone two semitones: one key between p.22

tonic the 1st note of the scale: home p.89

treble clef the G clef: it curls round the line for treble G p.26

triad three notes stacked: play one, skip one, play one p.106

trill the note and its neighbour above, back and forth quickly p.84

triplet three notes in the time of two p.61

turn above, the note, below, the note p.84

twelve-bar blues I I I I · IV IV I I · V IV I I p.140

una corda (u.c.) the left (soft) pedal p.81

upbeat see anacrusis p.61

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